LEX-IDI · LÉXICO TRANSVERSAL

Idioms y expresiones fijas

Teoría: lo que el C2 añade sobre el C1

v1 · octubre de 2026 · 280 expresiones en 11 temas más binomials y comparaciones · remisiones a UOE-P1 y UOE-P4

Este documento da por sabido el repertorio de idioms del C1 Advanced y recoge los que el C2 exige de más, organizados por temas. Las secciones 1 y 2 explican cómo se evalúan y qué parte de cada expresión es fija; de la 3 a la 13 van los temas; la 14 reúne binomials y comparaciones fijas, y la 15 es una tabla de repaso por palabra clave. Lo que ya explican UOE-P1_Teoria_v1 y UOE-P4_Teoria_v1 no se repite: se remite al final de cada tema. El asterisco (*) marca formas incorrectas.

1 Cómo se evalúan y cómo usar el documento

1.1 · Dónde aparecen en el examen

Parte	Cómo aparecen	Qué exige
Use of English · Part 1	Se suprime una palabra de la forma fija; las opciones son sinónimos de ella o palabras de otros idioms.	Reconocer la forma exacta: el significado no ayuda a elegir.
Use of English · Part 2	A veces el hueco es la palabra gramatical de una forma fija: artículo, preposición, own, that.	Saber qué artículo y qué preposición lleva cada expresión.
Use of English · Part 4	La palabra clave es el sustantivo del idiom y la frase 1 da el equivalente llano.	Pasar del significado llano a la forma completa y ajustarla a la frase: tiempo, posesivo, polaridad.
Reading · Parts 5–7	El idiom transmite la actitud del autor o una ironía; las preguntas de opinión dependen de él.	Captar el matiz, incluidas las variaciones y los proverbios recortados (§2.6).
Writing y Speaking	Cuentan para el criterio de léxico si son precisos y encajan con el registro.	Usar pocos y bien elegidos: un idiom forzado o mal construido resta precisión.

1.2 · Qué cambia respecto al C1

Aspecto	C1 Advanced	C2 Proficiency
Repertorio	Idioms frecuentes y transparentes (break the ice, a piece of cake)	Menos transparentes y más británicos (grasp the nettle, come a cropper, pay over the odds)
Forma	Basta con reconocerla de forma aproximada	Forma exacta: artículo, preposición, número, posesivo y polaridad (§2)
Uso	Comprender	Producir con el registro adecuado y adaptar la forma a la frase
Textos	Idioms en su forma canónica	Variaciones, juegos de palabras y proverbios recortados

1.3 · Cómo leer las tablas

- Cada entrada tiene cuatro columnas: la expresión, su registro, el significado en español (con notas de uso cuando hacen falta) y un ejemplo.

- En negrita, la palabra que suele suprimirse en la Part 1 o darse como clave en la Part 4. Es también la que ordena la tabla de la sección 15.
- sb (somebody), sth (something) y one's marcan huecos que se rellenan según la frase (§2.2). La barra separa variantes admitidas: grind to a standstill / halt.
- **Registro.** F: formal o escrito cuidado, adecuado en essay y report. N: neutro, vale en cualquier texto. I: informal; en conversación, o en un article o una review de tono ligero, pero no en essay ni report.
- **Ya en otra teoría**, al final de cada tema, lista las expresiones del tema que ya explican UOE-P1_Teoria_v1 o UOE-P4_Teoria_v1, con su apartado. No se repiten aquí.

CLAVE

Un idiom no se aprende con su traducción, sino con su forma completa (artículo, preposición, posesivo y polaridad), su registro y una frase de ejemplo. En el C2, saber lo que significa no basta para puntuar.

ESTRATEGIA DE EXAMEN

En Writing y en Speaking, un idiom bien elegido en el sitio justo suma; varios seguidos suenan a lista aprendida. En essay y report, solo registro F o N. Si dudas de la forma exacta, usa la expresión llana: un idiom mal construido resta más de lo que suma.

2 La forma fija: qué se puede cambiar y qué no

En el C2 se exige la forma exacta del idiom. En la Part 1, el distractor suele ser la versión casi correcta; en la Part 4, un artículo o una preposición de menos cuestan la mitad del ítem. Esta sección resume qué partes de una expresión fija no se tocan, cuáles se adaptan a la frase y qué variantes existen.

2.1 · Lo que no se toca: artículo, preposición, orden y número

Elemento	Forma correcta	Error típico
Artículo	under wraps · in the red · at a premium	*under the wraps · *in red · *at premium
Preposición	on the cards · at loggerheads with · beyond recognition	*in the cards (americano) · *in loggerheads · *over recognition
Orden	by leaps and bounds · neither here nor there	*by bounds and leaps · *neither there nor here
Número	pull strings · get to grips with · split hairs · bite the bullet	*pull a string · *get to grip with · *split a hair · *bite the bullets
Ortografía	free rein · to all intents and purposes	*free reign · *to all intensive purposes

OJO · TRAMPA TÍPICA

Un sinónimo invalida el idiom aunque el significado sea el mismo: *the judge is still out, *sink without a track, *a long shoot. En la Part 1, la opción que parece más lógica por significado suele ser la trampa.

2.2 · Lo que se adapta: posesivo, sujeto y tiempo

El verbo se conjuga con normalidad y los huecos marcados con one's, sb's o its se rellenan según la frase. En la Part 4, el posesivo que concuerda con el sujeto forma parte de la respuesta.

Hueco	Cómo se rellena	Ejemplo
one's	Posesivo que concuerda con el sujeto; con sujeto genérico, their.	They have all pulled their weight. · Any teacher worth their salt knows that.
sb's	Posesivo de la persona concreta.	I'm writing on the residents' behalf. · He expected staff to be at his beck and call.
its	Para cosas e instituciones.	The report doesn't mince its words. · Every chair has to earn its keep.
Intensificador	Algunos admiten un adverbio o un adjetivo dentro.	She took his comments very much to heart. · That is a very tall order indeed.

2.3 · Idioms de polaridad negativa

Algunos idioms solo existen en negativa, y otros casi siempre van con not, never, hardly, little o far from. Si la frase 1 de la Part 4 es negativa o compara a la baja (nowhere near as good as), la clave puede pedir uno de ellos, siempre con su negación: los de la primera fila no tienen forma afirmativa.

Polaridad	Idioms
Solo en negativa	not hold a candle to (§10) · not mince one's words (§10) · not believe a word of it (§6) · think none / not any the worse of (§8) · not have a leg to stand on (UOE-P4 §5.2) · not bat an eyelid (UOE-P1 §4.2)
Casi siempre en negativa	see eye to eye (§8) · lose sleep over (§9) · hold water (§10) · set in stone (§12) · plain sailing (§3)
Con never, little, no	see the light of day (§3) · make headway (§3) · nothing to write home about (§10)

2.4 · Pasiva y usos como adjetivo o sustantivo

Los idioms cuyo objeto conserva un sentido propio admiten pasiva, y la Part 4 lo aprovecha. Los que forman un bloque sin objeto real no la admiten.

Admite pasiva	No admite pasiva
Strings were pulled to get him the job.	*The day was called. (call it a day)
A blind eye was turned to the problem.	*The gun was jumped. (jump the gun)
The hatchet has finally been buried.	*The fence was sat on. (sit on the fence)
The plans are being kept under wraps.	*His luck was pushed. (push one's luck)
The minister was taken to task.	*The bullet was bitten. (bite the bullet)

Ante un sustantivo, muchos idioms se usan como adjetivo, con guiones; algunos tienen además forma de sustantivo. Es un recurso útil en Writing:

Idiom	Forma derivada	Ejemplo
one size fits all	one-size-fits-all	a one-size-fits-all approach to education
bricks and mortar	bricks-and-mortar	bricks-and-mortar retailers
hit and miss	hit-and-miss	a hit-and-miss service
cut and dried	cut-and-dried	a cut-and-dried case

Idiom	Forma derivada	Ejemplo
pass the buck	buck-passing	a culture of buck-passing
sit on the fence	fence-sitting	accused of fence-sitting

2.5 · Británico frente a americano

Los textos del examen siguen la norma británica. En la producción propia, lo importante es no mezclar variedades. Las que llevan § tienen su entrada en ese tema; las demás se explican aquí.

Británico	Americano	Significado
a new lease of life	a new lease on life	§12
at the end of one's tether	… rope	§9
on the cards	in the cards	§5
a drop in the ocean	… in the bucket	§13
take sth in one's stride	take sth in stride	§4
beat about the bush	beat around the bush	§6
hit and miss	hit or miss	§14
a skeleton in the cupboard	… in the closet	un secreto vergonzoso del pasado
a storm in a teacup	a tempest in a teapot	mucho ruido y pocas nueces: un escándalo por una nimiedad
not touch sth with a bargepole	… with a ten-foot pole	no querer saber nada de algo
sweep sth under the carpet	… under the rug	echar tierra encima de un problema
blow one's own trumpet	blow one's own horn	darse bombo
touch wood	knock on wood	toquemos madera

2.6 · Proverbios recortados y alusiones

Los textos de nivel C2, sobre todo los periodísticos, citan los proverbios a medias o los modifican, y dan por hecho que el lector reconoce el original. Basta con reconocer el comienzo.

Lo que aparece	Proverbio completo	Equivalente
every cloud… / the silver lining	every cloud has a silver lining	no hay mal que por bien no venga
too many cooks	too many cooks spoil the broth	muchas manos en un plato hacen mucho garabato
when in Rome	when in Rome, do as the Romans do	donde fueres, haz lo que vieres
the early bird	the early bird catches the worm	a quien madruga, Dios le ayuda
people in glass houses	people who live in glass houses shouldn't throw stones	quien tiene tejado de vidrio, que no tire piedras
a bird in the hand	a bird in the hand is worth two in the bush	más vale pájaro en mano que ciento volando

Lo que aparece	Proverbio completo	Equivalente
don't count your chickens	don't count your chickens before they're hatched	no vendas la piel del oso antes de cazarlo
no smoke without fire	there's no smoke without fire	cuando el río suena, agua lleva
the proof of the pudding	the proof of the pudding is in the eating	el valor de algo se demuestra al usarlo
the grass is always greener	the grass is always greener on the other side	nadie está contento con lo suyo

> EJEMPLO · ALUSIÓN EN UN TEXTO
>
> The merger cost hundreds of jobs. The silver lining, if there is one, is that the pension fund is now secure.
>
> El autor no cita el proverbio, pero the silver lining lo evoca: lo único positivo de una situación mala.

3 Éxito, fracaso y dificultad

Para valorar cómo sale un proyecto, una obra o un intento. Son muy frecuentes en prensa y en reseñas, y en la Part 1 suele suprimirse el sustantivo final de la expresión.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
come to **nothing**	N	fracasar, quedar en nada (un plan, un esfuerzo)	Years of negotiation came to nothing when the investors pulled out.
sink without **trace**	N	desaparecer sin pena ni gloria	Her first novel sank without trace; her second became a bestseller.
grind to a **standstill** / halt	N	paralizarse poco a poco	Traffic ground to a standstill as the snow grew heavier.
hard going	N	pesado, difícil de leer o de hacer	The opening chapters are hard going, but the book improves.
no **picnic**	I	nada fácil	Bringing up twins on your own is no picnic.
see the **light** of day	N	llegar a publicarse o a existir; suele ir con never	Many of his designs never saw the light of day.
a **head** start (on / over)	N	ventaja de salida	Children who are read to at home have a head start when they begin school.
fall **flat**	N	no surtir efecto (un chiste, una propuesta)	His attempts at humour fell flat with the audience.
a tall **order**	N	algo muy difícil de conseguir	Finishing the report by Friday is a tall order.
an uphill **struggle** / battle	N	una lucha cuesta arriba	Persuading the board to invest will be an uphill struggle.
plain **sailing**	N	coser y cantar; suele ir en negativa (far from, not)	The negotiations were far from plain sailing.
go from **strength** to strength	N	ir cada vez mejor	Since the new director arrived, the festival has gone from strength to strength.
fall by the **wayside**	N	quedarse por el camino	Of the forty people who started the course, half fell by the wayside.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
a flash in the **pan**	N	un éxito pasajero	Critics dismissed her early success as a flash in the pan.
back to the drawing **board**	N	vuelta a empezar tras un fracaso	The prototype failed every test, so it's back to the drawing board.
make **headway** (with / in)	N	avanzar, progresar; suele ir con little o no	Police are making little headway with the investigation.
hit a brick **wall**	N	toparse con un obstáculo insalvable	The talks hit a brick wall over the question of pay.
go to the **wall**	N	quebrar (una empresa)	Hundreds of small firms went to the wall during the recession.
make the **grade**	N	dar la talla	Only a handful of applicants make the grade each year.
come a **cropper**	I	darse un batacazo, fracasar de forma estrepitosa (británico)	The company came a cropper when it expanded too fast.
hold one's **own** (against)	N	defenderse bien, no quedarse atrás	She held her own against far more experienced players.
the tip of the **iceberg**	N	la punta del iceberg	The reported cases are only the tip of the iceberg.

OJO · TRAMPA TÍPICA

Tres idioms con wall y sentidos muy distintos: go to the wall (quebrar), hit a brick wall (atascarse) y drive sb up the wall (§9, sacar de quicio). En la Part 1, si wall ya está en el texto, el hueco es el verbo, y los verbos de los otros dos idioms son distractores naturales.

Ya en otra teoría: a blessing in disguise, by the skin of one's teeth (UOE-P1 §4.2) · take its toll on (UOE-P4 §5.1) · fall short of (UOE-P4 §7)

ÍTEM MODELO · PART 1

Despite a lavish launch campaign, the magazine sank without _____ within a year, and few readers even noticed that it had gone.

A mark **B** trace **C** track **D** sign

Respuesta: B · trace. Sink without trace: desaparecer sin que nadie lo note. Es una forma fija; ningún sinónimo de trace la sustituye.

A mark: aparece en otros idioms (make one's mark, wide of the mark, §6), no en este.

C track: forma lose track of y off the beaten track; *sink without track no existe.

D sign: es casi sinónimo de trace en sentido literal, justo lo que la forma fija no admite.

4 Esfuerzo, trabajo y ritmo

Cuánto se trabaja, a qué ritmo y con cuánta experiencia. Muchas llevan one's, que en la frase concuerda con el sujeto: they pulled their weight, she has her work cut out (§2.2).

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
work **flat** out	I	trabajar a tope	We've been working flat out to meet the deadline.
call it a **day**	N	dar por terminada la jornada o una actividad	After thirty years in politics, she has decided to call it a day.
from **scratch**	N	desde cero	The software had to be rewritten from scratch.
have time on one's **hands**	N	tener tiempo libre, a menudo más del que se quisiera	Since he retired, he has had too much time on his hands.
with time to **spare**	N	con margen de sobra respecto a un plazo	We reached the station with ten minutes to spare.
take sth a **stage** / step further	N	llevar algo un paso más allá	The new law takes the principle a stage further.
set **foot** in / on	N	pisar, entrar en; casi siempre con never o first	She had never set foot in a laboratory before she started university.
pull one's **weight**	N	hacer la parte que le toca	If everyone pulled their weight, we would finish by noon.
have one's **work** cut out	N	tenerlo muy difícil, tener mucho trabajo por delante	The new head teacher will have her work cut out to restore morale.
get to **grips** with	N	llegar a dominar algo difícil; afrontarlo	It took me months to get to grips with the new system.
take sth in one's **stride**	N	tomarse algo con naturalidad, sin que le afecte (británico)	She took her sudden fame in her stride.
in full **swing**	N	en pleno apogeo	By ten o'clock the party was in full swing.
go the extra **mile**	N	hacer un esfuerzo adicional	The staff went the extra mile to make us feel welcome.
burn the midnight **oil**	N	quemarse las pestañas, trabajar hasta muy tarde	Students were burning the midnight oil before their finals.
keep one's nose to the **grindstone**	I	trabajar sin descanso	Keep your nose to the grindstone and you'll pass.
have a lot on one's **plate**	I	tener muchas cosas entre manos	I can't take on another project: I've got a lot on my plate.
spread oneself too **thin**	N	abarcar demasiado	The charity spread itself too thin by opening offices in ten countries.
at full **stretch**	N	al límite de su capacidad (británico)	Hospitals have been working at full stretch all winter.
rise to the **occasion**	N	estar a la altura de las circunstancias	The understudy rose to the occasion magnificently.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
cut one's **teeth** (on)	N	foguearse, adquirir la primera experiencia	She cut her teeth on local newspapers before joining the BBC.
leave no **stone** unturned	N	no dejar piedra por mover	Police have promised to leave no stone unturned in their search.

OJO · TRAMPA TÍPICA

Have time on one's hands sugiere tiempo libre que no se sabe en qué emplear; with time to spare indica margen respecto a un plazo. No son intercambiables: *we arrived with ten minutes on our hands no existe.

Ya en otra teoría: learn the ropes, cut corners (UOE-P1 §4.2) · at a loose end (UOE-P4 §5.2) · keep pace with (UOE-P4 §5.1) · spare no effort (UOE-P4 §7)

ÍTEM MODELO · PART 1

Throughout the takeover, most of the staff simply kept their noses to the _____, hoping that hard work would protect their jobs.

A millstone **B** grindstone **C** cornerstone **D** milestone

Respuesta: B · grindstone. Keep one's nose to the grindstone: trabajar sin descanso. Las cuatro opciones acaban en -stone; solo grindstone (la piedra de afilar) forma el idiom.

A millstone: forma otro idiom: a millstone round one's neck, una carga que impide avanzar.

C cornerstone: es la piedra angular, el pilar de algo (the cornerstone of the policy); no va con nose.

D milestone: es un hito (a milestone in her career); no forma idiom con keep one's nose to.

5 Riesgo, azar y probabilidad

Cuánto se arriesga y qué probabilidad hay. En la Part 4 es habitual pasar de un adjetivo llano (uncertain, unlikely, risky) a una de estas formas.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
beat the **odds**	N	lograrlo contra todo pronóstico	The tiny firm beat the odds and survived the recession.
be **down** to sb / sth	N	deberse a algo; ser cosa de alguien	Whether you win is largely down to luck. · It's down to you to decide.
anyone's **guess**	N	algo que nadie sabe	What happens after the election is anyone's guess.
a long **shot**	N	una posibilidad remota que se intenta igualmente	It's a long shot, but she might still be at the office.
a safe **bet**	N	una apuesta segura	It's a safe bet that prices will rise again.
a dead **cert**	I	cosa segura (británico)	The favourite looked a dead cert to win.
push one's **luck**	I	tentar la suerte, abusar de una situación favorable	You've been late twice this week, so don't push your luck.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
tempt **fate**	N	tentar a la suerte: decir o hacer algo que parece atraer la desgracia	I don't want to tempt fate, but I think we've won.
err on the side of **caution**	N	pecar de prudente	If in doubt, err on the side of caution.
hang in the **balance**	N	estar en el aire, pendiente de un hilo	The future of the factory hangs in the balance.
hedge one's **bets**	N	no jugárselo todo a una carta	Many investors are hedging their bets by buying gold.
put all one's eggs in one **basket**	N	jugárselo todo a una carta	Relying on a single customer means putting all your eggs in one basket.
sail close to the **wind**	N	rozar lo ilegal o lo inaceptable	His accounting methods sail rather close to the wind.
skate on thin **ice**	N	pisar terreno peligroso	You're skating on thin ice if you criticise the chairman in public.
the odds are **stacked** against	N	tenerlo todo en contra	The odds are stacked against small producers.
play it **safe**	N	no arriesgarse	We decided to play it safe and book in advance.
chance one's **arm**	I	arriesgarse a intentar algo (británico)	I chanced my arm and asked for a pay rise.
the luck of the **draw**	N	cuestión de suerte	Which examiner you get is the luck of the draw.
more by luck than **judgement**	N	más por suerte que por acierto	We arrived on time more by luck than judgement.
a shot in the **dark**	N	una conjetura a ciegas	My answer was a shot in the dark, but it turned out to be right.
on the **cards**	N	probable, previsible (británico; en americano, in the cards)	An early election is on the cards.

OJO · TRAMPA TÍPICA

A long shot es un intento con pocas probabilidades de éxito; a shot in the dark es una conjetura hecha sin datos. Y beat the odds (lograrlo) es lo contrario de the odds are stacked against (tenerlo todo en contra).

Ya en otra teoría: touch and go (UOE-P1 §4.1) · a foregone conclusion (UOE-P1 §3.2) · at stake, against all the odds (UOE-P4 §5.2) · stand a chance, on the off chance, in all likelihood (UOE-P4 §7)

ÍTEM MODELO · PART 4

It is still uncertain whether the treaty will be ratified.

BALANCE

The ratification of the treaty _____.

Respuesta: STILL HANGS IN THE BALANCE (5 palabras)

También: IS STILL HANGING IN THE BALANCE (6) · **IS STILL IN THE BALANCE** (5) · **STILL REMAINS IN THE BALANCE** (5) · **REMAINS IN THE BALANCE** (4)

Qué se puntúa: el verbo en presente con still (o remains, que ya lo implica) y el idiom completo, con artículo: in the balance. Sin the se pierde esa mitad.

6 Información, conocimiento y secretos

Saber, no saber, ocultar y revelar. Buena parte de estos idioms aparecen en la Part 4 con un sustantivo inesperado como clave (WRAPS, WIND, GOSPEL).

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
let the **cat** out of the bag	I	irse de la lengua, desvelar un secreto	Someone let the cat out of the bag about the merger.
keep sth to **oneself**	N	guardarse algo, no contarlo	Keep this to yourself, but I'm thinking of resigning.
give the **game** away	N	delatar lo que se pretendía ocultar	Her nervous laugh gave the game away.
keep a low **profile**	N	no llamar la atención, pasar desapercibido	After the scandal, the minister kept a low profile for months.
turn a blind **eye** (to)	N	hacer la vista gorda	For years the authorities turned a blind eye to the illegal trade.
jump to **conclusions**	N	sacar conclusiones precipitadas	Don't jump to conclusions before you've heard both sides.
the **jury** is (still) out (on)	N	aún no hay veredicto, no está claro	The jury is still out on whether the reform has worked.
wide of the **mark**	N	desencaminado, muy inexacto	Early estimates of the cost were wide of the mark.
not believe a **word** of it	N	no creerse nada; solo en negativa	He said he had been ill, but I didn't believe a word of it.
take / treat sth as **gospel**	N	creerse algo a pies juntillas (también read sth as gospel)	Don't take everything you read online as gospel.
all at **sea**	N	perdido, desconcertado	Faced with the new tax rules, many small traders are all at sea.
know sth back to **front**	N	saberse algo al dedillo; sin know, back to front significa «del revés» (lo de atrás delante)	She knows the regulations back to front. · He had put his jumper on back to front.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
a bit of a **mouthful**	I	un nombre largo y difícil de pronunciar	The official title is a bit of a mouthful, so everyone just calls it 'the Act'.
get **wind** of	N	enterarse de algo que se quería ocultar	The press got wind of the plan before it was announced.
hear sth on the **grapevine**	I	enterarse por rumores	I heard on the grapevine that she's leaving.
an open **secret**	N	un secreto a voces	It was an open secret that the two partners disliked each other.
under **wraps**	N	en secreto (keep sth under wraps)	The design is being kept under wraps until the launch.
put two and two **together**	N	atar cabos	She put two and two together and realised who had sent the letter.
take sth at face **value**	N	tomar algo por lo que aparenta, sin cuestionarlo	His apology should not be taken at face value.
get the wrong end of the **stick**	I	entender algo al revés (británico)	You've got the wrong end of the stick: I wasn't criticising you.
be none the **wiser**	N	seguir sin entender; también, no enterarse de algo	I read the instructions twice and was none the wiser.
beat about the **bush**	I	andarse con rodeos (británico; en americano, around)	Stop beating about the bush and tell me what happened.

OJO · TRAMPA TÍPICA

Be none the wiser tiene dos sentidos: «seguir sin entender» (el ejemplo de la tabla) y «no enterarse», a menudo con any: If you borrow it, nobody will be any the wiser. El contexto decide cuál es.

Ya en otra teoría: take sth with a pinch of salt (UOE-P1 §4.2) · shed light on (UOE-P1 §3.1) · in the dark, cross one's mind, take my word for it (UOE-P4 §5.2) · come to light (UOE-P4 §5.1) · not have the faintest idea (UOE-P4 §7) · to the best of my knowledge (UOE-P4 §5.4)

ÍTEM MODELO · PART 4

The negotiations are being kept secret until the deal is signed.

WRAPS

The negotiations _____ until the deal is signed.

Respuesta: ARE BEING KEPT UNDER WRAPS (5 palabras)

También: WILL BE KEPT UNDER WRAPS (5)

Qué se puntúa: la pasiva continua (are being kept) y el idiom sin artículo (under wraps; *under the wraps pierde esa mitad).

7 Poder, influencia y control

Quién manda, quién influye y quién cede. Varias admiten pasiva (strings were pulled, she was given free rein), un recurso muy explotado en la Part 4 (§2.4).

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
pull **strings**	N	mover hilos, usar enchufes	Her uncle pulled strings to get her the job.
hold **sway** (over)	F	dominar, ejercer gran influencia	Such ideas still hold sway in rural areas.
give sb free **rein** (to)	N	dar carta blanca, rienda suelta	The director was given free rein to recast the play.
play second **fiddle** (to)	N	quedar en segundo plano, a la sombra de otro	She was tired of playing second fiddle to her brother.
have the final **say** / the last word	N	tener la última palabra (decidir); the last word es también ganar una discusión	The board has the final say on all appointments.
carry **weight** (with)	N	tener peso, autoridad	Her opinion carries a lot of weight with the committee.
call the **shots**	I	mandar, cortar el bacalao	It's the investors who call the shots now.
rule the **roost**	I	llevar la batuta	In that household, the grandmother rules the roost.
gain / have the upper **hand**	N	tomar ventaja, imponerse	After a poor start, the visitors gradually gained the upper hand.
hold all the **cards**	N	tener la sartén por el mango	In this negotiation, the buyer holds all the cards.
have sb over a **barrel**	I	tener a alguien contra las cuerdas	They had us over a barrel: we had no choice but to accept.
pass the **buck**	I	pasar la pelota, eludir la responsabilidad; the buck stops here: la responsabilidad es mía	Ministers keep passing the buck to local councils.
throw one's **weight** about	I	mangonear, imponerse con prepotencia (en americano, around)	The new supervisor likes to throw her weight about.
a force to be **reckoned** with	N	un rival o un poder que hay que tener muy en cuenta	The party has become a force to be reckoned with.
have a **hand** in	N	tener que ver en, intervenir en	Several advisers had a hand in drafting the speech.
keep sb / sth on a tight **rein**	N	atar en corto, controlar de cerca	The new manager keeps spending on a tight rein.
at sb's beck and **call**	N	a entera disposición de alguien, de forma servil	He expected his staff to be at his beck and call.
stand one's **ground**	N	mantenerse firme, no ceder	Despite the protests, the council stood its ground.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
bring sb to **heel**	N	meter en cintura	The government is determined to bring the banks to heel.
call sb to **account** (for)	F	pedir cuentas a alguien	Nobody has yet been called to account for the failures.
turn the **tables** (on)	N	dar la vuelta a la tortilla	In the second half, the visitors turned the tables on their rivals.
put one's **foot** down	N	plantarse, imponer su autoridad	When the costs kept rising, the director put her foot down.

OJO · TRAMPA TÍPICA

Rein (rienda) y reign (reinado) suenan igual: free rein y a tight rein se escriben con rein. En la Part 4 una falta de ortografía cuesta la mitad del ítem, y *free reign es de las más frecuentes, incluso entre nativos.

Ya en otra teoría: toe the line (UOE-P1 §4.2) · at the mercy of (UOE-P1 §4.3) · wield power (UOE-P1 §3.1) · have a say in (UOE-P4 §5.1) · out of hand (UOE-P4 §5.2) · at sb's disposal (UOE-P4 §5.4)

ÍTEM MODELO · PART 1

For much of the twentieth century, these ideas held _____ over the medical profession, and few doctors dared to question them.

A grip **B** sway **C** swing **D** sweep

Respuesta: B · sway. Hold sway (over): dominar, ejercer gran influencia. Es una forma fija, sin artículo.

A grip: exige artículo y otra preposición (have a grip on) o forma get to grips with (§4); *hold grip over no existe.

C swing: aparece en in full swing (§4), no con hold.

D sweep: forma a clean sweep (arrasar), no *hold sweep.

8 Relaciones y trato con los demás

Acuerdo y conflicto, cercanía y distancia. Varias llevan un hueco sb o sb's que se rellena con la persona concreta (§2.2).

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
part **company** (with)	N	separarse, romper una relación, también profesional	The singer parted company with the band in 2015.
take a **liberty** / liberties (with)	N	pasarse de la raya; take liberties with a text: tergiversarlo	The film takes considerable liberties with the historical facts.
spare a **thought** for	N	acordarse de quien lo está pasando mal	Spare a thought for those working over Christmas.
on sb's **behalf** / on behalf of sb	N	en nombre de, de parte de	I'm writing on behalf of the residents' association.
sing sb's **praises**	N	poner a alguien por las nubes	Her former students still sing her praises.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
take sb to **task** (for)	F	reprender, criticar con dureza	The report takes the government to task for its lack of planning.
think none / not any the **worse** of sb	N	no tener peor concepto de alguien (por algo); va en negativa	I wouldn't think any the worse of you if you said no.
from an unlikely **quarter**	N	de donde menos se esperaba	Support for the plan came from an unlikely quarter: the opposition.
see **eye** to eye (with sb on sth)	N	estar de acuerdo; suele ir en negativa	We don't always see eye to eye on politics.
at **loggerheads** (with / over)	N	enfrentados	Residents are at loggerheads with the council over the plans.
bury the **hatchet**	N	hacer las paces	After years of rivalry, the two brothers finally buried the hatchet.
clear the **air**	N	aclarar las cosas tras un malentendido o una tensión	A frank conversation helped to clear the air.
a bone of **contention**	N	la manzana de la discordia	The boundary has long been a bone of contention between the two farms.
give sb / sth a wide **berth**	N	evitar, mantenerse lejos de	Locals give that stretch of coast a wide berth in winter.
bend over **backwards** (to)	N	desvivirse por ayudar o complacer	The hotel staff bent over backwards to help us.
pay lip **service** to	N	apoyar algo de boquilla	Many companies pay lip service to diversity.
keep sb at arm's **length**	N	mantener a alguien a distancia	She keeps journalists at arm's length.
put sb's **nose** out of joint	I	molestar u ofender, a menudo al verse desplazado	Her promotion put a few noses out of joint.
give sb the cold **shoulder**	N	hacer el vacío a alguien	After the argument, his colleagues gave him the cold shoulder.
in sb's good / bad **books**	I	gozar (o no) del favor de alguien	I'm in my sister's bad books for forgetting her birthday.
hold out an olive **branch**	N	tender la mano, en señal de reconciliación	The new leader held out an olive branch to the unions.
take sb under one's **wing**	N	tomar a alguien bajo su protección	An older colleague took me under her wing.

OJO · TRAMPA TÍPICA

Tres usos de liberty: I took the liberty of booking a table (cortesía: «me he permitido»), that was taking a liberty (pasarse de la raya) y take liberties with the facts (tergiversarlos). La forma con of + -ing es la única que no critica.

Ya en otra teoría: give and take (UOE-P1 §4.1) · give sb the benefit of the doubt, make allowances for (UOE-P4 §5.1) · hold sb in high regard, go out of one's way (UOE-P4 §5.2) · on good terms with, lose touch with (UOE-P4 §7) · for sb's sake (UOE-P4 §5.4)

ÍTEM MODELO · PART 1

After a decade of public feuding, the two former business partners have finally agreed to bury the _____.

A axe **B** hatchet **C** sword **D** weapon

Respuesta: B · hatchet. Bury the hatchet: hacer las paces. La forma es fija y no admite sinónimos de hatchet.

A axe: es casi sinónimo de hatchet y forma otro idiom: have an axe to grind (tener un interés personal en algo).

C sword: aparece en cross swords with (enfrentarse) y en a double-edged sword (§10), no aquí.

D weapon: es el sentido literal; el idiom no lo admite.

9 Emociones y estados de ánimo

Preocupación, irritación, ánimo y desánimo. Son frecuentes en los textos narrativos de Reading y en la Part 3 de Listening, donde a menudo revelan la actitud del hablante.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
lose **sleep** over	N	preocuparse mucho por algo; casi siempre en negativa	It's a minor error; I wouldn't lose any sleep over it.
in high **spirits**	N	de muy buen humor, eufórico	The team returned home in high spirits.
drive sb up the **wall**	I	sacar de quicio	The constant drilling next door is driving me up the wall.
grind one's **teeth**	N	rechinar los dientes (de rabia, o dormido)	He listened to the criticism, grinding his teeth.
take sth to **heart**	N	tomarse algo a pecho; también, tomarse en serio un consejo	Don't take his remarks to heart; he's like that with everyone.
with good / bad **grace**	N	de buen / mal grado	She accepted defeat with good grace.
make one's **peace** with	N	reconciliarse con algo o alguien, aceptarlo	He has made his peace with the fact that he will never play again.
break the **spell**	N	romper el encanto o el hechizo	A mobile phone rang and broke the spell.
glued to one's screen	I	pegado a la pantalla (también glued to the television)	Millions were glued to their screens for the final.
look over one's **shoulder**	N	vivir con la inquietud de ser descubierto o superado	Even after his release, he spent years looking over his shoulder.
have nothing to **prove**	N	no tener que demostrar nada a nadie	After three world titles, she has nothing left to prove.
at the end of one's **tether**	N	al límite de la paciencia o de las fuerzas (británico; en americano, rope)	After a week without sleep, I was at the end of my tether.
at one's wits' **end**	N	desesperado, sin saber qué más hacer	Parents are at their wits' end trying to find school places.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
get sb's **back** up	I	irritar a alguien, ponerle a la defensiva	His arrogant manner gets everyone's back up.
rub sb up the wrong **way**	I	caer mal, irritar sin querer (británico)	She has a talent for rubbing people up the wrong way.
a chip on one's **shoulder** (about)	I	resentimiento por sentirse menospreciado	He has always had a chip on his shoulder about not going to university.
keep a stiff upper **lip**	N	no mostrar las emociones, aguantar sin quejarse	The British are supposed to keep a stiff upper lip.
put a brave **face** on sth	N	poner al mal tiempo buena cara (también put on a brave face)	She put a brave face on the defeat.
touch a raw **nerve**	N	tocar un tema sensible (también hit a nerve)	His comments about money clearly touched a raw nerve.
lose **heart**	N	desanimarse	Don't lose heart: the first year is always the hardest.
be beside **oneself** (with)	N	estar fuera de sí (de rabia, de alegría, de preocupación)	She was beside herself with worry when her son didn't come home.
on **tenterhooks**	N	en ascuas	We were kept on tenterhooks until the results were announced.

OJO · TRAMPA TÍPICA

Heart forma idioms con sentidos opuestos: take sth to heart (tomárselo a pecho), lose heart (desanimarse), a change of heart (§11, cambiar de opinión) y set one's heart on (UOE-P4 §5.2, desear mucho). En la Part 1 el hueco suele ser el verbo, y los verbos de los otros idioms de la familia son distractores naturales.

Ya en otra teoría: not bat an eyelid (UOE-P1 §4.2) · harbour a grudge, strike a chord (UOE-P1 §3.1) · a pang of guilt, a flicker of hope (UOE-P1 §3.4) · on edge, set one's heart on, at a loss for words (UOE-P4 §5.2)

ÍTEM MODELO · PART 4

Her criticism upset me because I respect her opinion.

HEART

I _____ because I respect her opinion.

Respuesta: TOOK HER CRITICISM TO HEART (5 palabras)

También: TOOK TO HEART HER CRITICISM (5)

Qué se puntúa: el cambio de sujeto, con her criticism como objeto de took, y el idiom con su preposición (to heart; sin to, *took her criticism heart, se pierde esa mitad).

10 Juicio, crítica y comparación

Para valorar, comparar y criticar. Es el tema que más rinde en Writing (essay, review) y en la Part 3 de Speaking; el lenguaje argumentativo no idiomático (conectores, adjetivos de valoración) está en LEX-ARG.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
not hold a **candle** to	N	no tener ni punto de comparación con; solo en negativa	Her later novels don't hold a candle to her first.
not mince one's **words**	N	no tener pelos en la lengua; solo en negativa	The report doesn't mince its words about the failures of management.
a case in **point**	N	un ejemplo claro de lo que se acaba de decir	Many towns have lost their banks; Hexham is a case in point.
a fine **line** (between)	N	una frontera muy fina entre dos cosas	There is a fine line between confidence and arrogance.
a different **matter** altogether	N	harina de otro costal (también quite another matter)	Writing a novel is one thing; getting it published is a different matter altogether.
on **paper** … in practice	N	en teoría … en la práctica	On paper, the scheme looks excellent; in practice, it will be hard to run.
on its own **terms**	N	por lo que es, sin compararlo con otra cosa	The film should be judged on its own terms, not as an adaptation.
a rule of **thumb**	N	una regla práctica y aproximada	As a rule of thumb, allow an hour for every ten pages.
for its own **sake**	N	por sí mismo, sin otro fin	Novelty for its own sake adds nothing to a building.
for the **look** of the thing	N	para guardar las apariencias (británico)	He attended the meeting purely for the look of the thing.
of every **stripe**	N	de todo signo o tendencia	Politicians of every stripe condemned the attack.
warts and **all**	N	con todos sus defectos; admite variaciones creativas (quirks and all)	The biography presents its subject warts and all.
in no small **part** / measure	F	en gran medida	The festival's success is due in no small part to its volunteers.
leave a lot to be **desired**	N	dejar mucho que desear	The service at the hotel left a lot to be desired.
a cut **above**	N	un escalón por encima	Her work is a cut above that of her contemporaries.
pale into **insignificance** (beside)	N	palidecer en comparación	Our problems pale into insignificance beside theirs.
poles **apart**	N	diametralmente opuestos	Politically, the two candidates are poles apart.
hold **water**	N	(un argumento) sostenerse; casi siempre en negativa	His explanation simply doesn't hold water.
a double-edged **sword**	N	un arma de doble filo	Fame is a double-edged sword.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
a red **herring**	N	una pista falsa, algo que distrae del asunto	The question of cost is a red herring; the real issue is safety.
neither here nor **there**	N	irrelevante	Whether he meant to cause offence is neither here nor there.
split **hairs**	N	hilar demasiado fino, buscarle tres pies al gato	Let's not split hairs over the exact wording.
damn sb / sth with faint **praise**	F	criticar mediante un elogio tibio	The review damned the film with faint praise, calling it 'perfectly adequate'.
nothing to write **home** about	I	nada del otro mundo	The food was nothing to write home about.

OJO · TRAMPA TÍPICA

Cuatro expresiones con terms: judge sth on its own terms (por lo que es), on one's own terms (con sus condiciones: she left on her own terms), in terms of (en cuanto a, UOE-P4 §7) y come to terms with (aceptar, UOE-P4 §5.1). En la Part 1 la preposición decide.

Ya en otra teoría: a far cry from, par for the course (UOE-P1 §4.2) · a sweeping generalisation (UOE-P1 §3.2) · tread a fine line (UOE-P1 §9) · on a par with, beside the point, by no stretch of the imagination (UOE-P4 §5.2) · take issue with, take exception to, come under fire (UOE-P4 §5.1) · second to none (UOE-P4 §3.7)

ÍTEM MODELO · PART 4

The sequel is nowhere near as good as the original film.

CANDLE

The sequel _____ the original film.

Respuesta: DOES NOT HOLD A CANDLE TO (6 palabras)

También: DOESN'T HOLD A CANDLE TO (6) · **CANNOT HOLD A CANDLE TO** (5) · **CAN'T HOLD A CANDLE TO** (6)

Qué se puntúa: la negación (el idiom solo existe en negativa: *holds a candle to pierde esa mitad) y el idiom completo con su preposición (hold a candle to).

11 Decisiones, planes y prioridades

Decidir, dudar, lanzarse o echarse atrás. Muchas resumen en tres o cuatro palabras una actitud que la frase 1 de la Part 4 describe con una oración entera.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
steer a middle **course** (between)	N	buscar un término medio	The government tried to steer a middle course between the two factions.
leave it at **that**	N	dejarlo ahí, no decir ni hacer más	Let's just say we disagreed and leave it at that.
on a **whim**	N	por capricho, por un impulso	She bought the cottage on a whim after a weekend in Cornwall.
assume / fear the **worst**	N	ponerse en lo peor	When he didn't call, his parents assumed the worst.
defeat the **object** / purpose (of)	N	echar por tierra el propósito de algo	Driving to the gym rather defeats the object of exercising.
one-size-fits-**all**	N	(enfoque) único para todos, sin adaptar; va delante del sustantivo	A one-size-fits-all approach ignores the needs of individual pupils.
sit on the **fence**	N	no mojarse	On the question of independence, the party continues to sit on the fence.
have second **thoughts** (about)	N	dudar de una decisión ya tomada	I'm having second thoughts about the move.
think **better** of sth / -ing	N	pensárselo mejor y no hacerlo	He was about to complain, but thought better of it.
a change of **heart**	N	un cambio de opinión o de actitud	The minister has had a change of heart over the cuts.
take the **plunge**	N	lanzarse, tras dudarlo mucho	After years of renting, they took the plunge and bought a flat.
bite the **bullet**	N	hacer de tripas corazón (afrontar algo desagradable)	We'll have to bite the bullet and raise prices.
grasp the **nettle**	N	coger el toro por los cuernos (británico)	The council must grasp the nettle and close the old library.
jump the **gun**	N	precipitarse, adelantarse	Some newspapers jumped the gun and announced the result early.
put the cart before the **horse**	N	empezar la casa por el tejado	Buying furniture before finding a flat is putting the cart before the horse.
draw a **line** under	N	dar por zanjado	It's time to draw a line under the affair and move on.
back to square **one**	N	vuelta al punto de partida	The deal collapsed, and we were back to square one.
keep one's **options** open	N	no comprometerse todavía	I'm keeping my options open until I hear from both universities.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
cross that **bridge** when we come to it	N	ya nos preocuparemos cuando llegue el momento	What if it rains? We'll cross that bridge when we come to it.
call sb's **bluff**	N	obligar a alguien a cumplir una amenaza que se cree un farol	The union threatened to strike, and the management called their bluff.
get sth off the **ground**	N	poner algo en marcha	It took two years to get the project off the ground.

OJO · TRAMPA TÍPICA

Think better of sth es «pensárselo mejor y no hacerlo»; think the worse of sb (§8) es «tener peor concepto de alguien». Y have second thoughts no implica renunciar: solo dudar.

Ya en otra teoría: on the spur of the moment (UOE-P1 §4.2) · strike a balance (UOE-P1 §3.1) · play it by ear (UOE-P4 §5.2) · make up one's mind, in two minds (UOE-P4 §7) · take sth into account, have no option but to (UOE-P4 §5.1) · with a view to (UOE-P4 §5.4)

ÍTEM MODELO · PART 4

In the end, she decided not to say anything.

BETTER

In the end, she _____ anything.

Respuesta: THOUGHT BETTER OF SAYING (4 palabras)

También: THOUGHT BETTER OF IT AND DIDN'T SAY (8)

Qué se puntúa: el idiom (thought better of) y la forma en -ing que exige la preposición (saying; *of to say pierde esa mitad).

12 Tiempo, cambio y permanencia

Lo que cambia, lo que dura y lo que llega tarde o a tiempo. Abundan en textos de divulgación histórica y en las reseñas de Writing.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
a thing of the **past**	N	algo del pasado, que ya no existe	Paper tickets will soon be a thing of the past.
in its / sb's **heyday**	N	en su época de esplendor	In its heyday, the port employed ten thousand people.
the **ravages** of time	F	los estragos del tiempo	The frescoes have survived the ravages of time remarkably well.
not what it **was**	N	ya no es lo que era (también not what it used to be)	The village pub is not what it was.
for **good**	N	para siempre, definitivamente	She has left the country for good.
the best **part** of	N	casi todo (casi una hora, la mayor parte de un año)	I spent the best part of an hour on hold.
preserved in **aspic**	N	anclado en el pasado, sin cambiar (con matiz crítico)	The town centre seems preserved in aspic.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
on **cue**	N	en el momento justo, como si estuviera ensayado (también right on cue)	Right on cue, the sun came out.
at the press of a **button**	N	con solo pulsar un botón (también at the touch of a button)	Today, almost any song is available at the press of a button.
beyond (all) **recognition**	N	hasta quedar irreconocible	The town has changed beyond recognition.
at the eleventh **hour**	N	en el último momento	The strike was called off at the eleventh hour.
in one fell **swoop**	N	de un golpe, de una sola vez	The fire destroyed the whole collection in one fell swoop.
at a **stroke**	N	de un plumazo	The new law abolished the old privileges at a stroke.
turn the **tide**	N	cambiar el curso de una situación (the tide is turning: las cosas cambian)	The new vaccine helped to turn the tide against the disease.
have had its / one's **day**	N	haber pasado su momento	The fax machine has had its day.
past its sell-by **date**	I	caducado, obsoleto (en sentido figurado)	The format is well past its sell-by date.
a new lease of **life**	N	un nuevo impulso, una nueva vida (británico; en americano, lease on life)	The restoration has given the old cinema a new lease of life.
stand the test of **time**	N	resistir el paso del tiempo	Her designs have stood the test of time.
set in **stone**	N	inamovible; suele ir en negativa	The timetable isn't set in stone.
once in a blue **moon**	I	de Pascuas a Ramos	We see each other once in a blue moon.
ahead of one's / its **time**	N	adelantado a su tiempo	His ideas on education were ahead of their time.
on the **wane**	F	en declive	The influence of the old parties is on the wane.
in the **pipeline**	N	en preparación, en camino	Several new projects are in the pipeline.

OJO · TRAMPA TÍPICA

For good significa «para siempre», no «para bien»: She has left for good. «Por el bien de» es for the good of o for sb's sake (UOE-P4 §5.4).

Ya en otra teoría: in the nick of time, in the offing, at the drop of a hat (UOE-P1 §4.2) · in the wake of (UOE-P1 §4.3) · give way to (UOE-P4 §5.1) · at short notice, for the time being, in due course, in the long run, a matter of time (UOE-P4 §7)

ÍTEM MODELO · PART 1

The agreement was reached at the eleventh _____, only minutes before the strike was due to begin.

A minute **B** hour **C** moment **D** second

Respuesta: B · hour. At the eleventh hour: en el último momento. El ordinal y el sustantivo son fijos.

A minute: va con last, no con eleventh: at the last minute es otro idiom.

C moment: también va con last (at the last moment), nunca con eleventh.

D second: no forma ningún idiom con eleventh; atrae solo porque es una unidad de tiempo.

13 Dinero, recursos y valor

Gastar, ahorrar y valorar lo que algo aporta. Junto al registro informal típico del tema, hay formas F útiles en report (turn sth to account, at a premium).

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
earn its **keep** / its place	N	justificar lo que cuesta / merecer el sitio que ocupa	In a small flat, every piece of furniture has to earn its keep.
bricks and mortar	N	inmuebles; comercio físico frente al online (bricks-and-mortar ante sustantivo)	Bricks-and-mortar shops are struggling to compete with online retailers.
change **hands**	N	cambiar de dueño	The painting has changed hands several times since 1900.
turn sth to (good) **account**	F	sacar provecho de algo	She turned her knowledge of languages to good account in the diplomatic service.
make ends **meet**	N	llegar a fin de mes	Many families are struggling to make ends meet.
tighten one's **belt**	N	apretarse el cinturón	With energy prices rising, households are tightening their belts.
live beyond one's **means**	N	vivir por encima de sus posibilidades	For years, the country lived beyond its means.
foot the **bill** (for)	N	pagar la cuenta, a menudo a disgusto	Taxpayers will have to foot the bill for the repairs.
pay over the **odds**	I	pagar de más (británico)	We paid over the odds for the house, but we love it.
on a **shoestring**	I	con muy poco dinero	The film was made on a shoestring.
a white **elephant**	N	algo caro e inútil, sobre todo un edificio o un proyecto	The new stadium has become a white elephant.
a drop in the **ocean**	N	una gota en el océano (británico; en americano, in the bucket)	The aid promised is a drop in the ocean compared with what is needed.
cut one's **losses**	N	cortar por lo sano, retirarse antes de perder más	The firm decided to cut its losses and close the branch.

Expresión	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
worth one's **salt**	N	que se precie	Any teacher worth their salt knows that.
at a **premium**	N	escaso y, por eso, caro o muy valorado	Space is at a premium in the city centre.
pay through the **nose** (for)	I	pagar un dineral	Fans paid through the nose for tickets.
in the **red** / in the black	N	en números rojos / con saldo positivo	The company has been in the red for three years.
get one's money's **worth**	N	sacarle partido a lo pagado	At that price, you certainly get your money's worth.
feather one's (own) **nest**	N	forrarse, a menudo abusando de un cargo	He was accused of feathering his own nest at the shareholders' expense.
strapped for **cash**	I	corto de dinero	Many students are strapped for cash by the end of term.
a cash **cow**	N	una fuente de ingresos segura	The old product line remains the company's cash cow.
hold the purse **strings**	N	controlar el dinero	In most households, one person holds the purse strings.

OJO · TRAMPA TÍPICA

Odds aparece en cuatro expresiones distintas: pay over the odds (pagar de más), beat the odds y the odds are stacked against (§5) y at odds with (en desacuerdo, UOE-P1 §4.3). Cuando el hueco es la preposición (over, at, against), solo el sentido de la frase decide.

Ya en otra teoría: incur costs (UOE-P1 §3.1) · a heavy price (UOE-P1 §3.2) · at the expense of (UOE-P4 §5.4) · spare no expense, worth sb's while (UOE-P4 §7)

ÍTEM MODELO · PART 4

The flat cost us more than it was really worth.

ODDS

We _____ the flat.

Respuesta: PAID OVER THE ODDS FOR (5 palabras)

Qué se puntúa: el cambio de sujeto, que obliga a paid … for, y el idiom con su artículo (over the odds).

14 Binomials y comparaciones fijas

Formas fijas que no pertenecen a un tema concreto y que la Part 1 evalúa por su forma: se suprime una de las dos palabras del binomial, o el sustantivo de la comparación, y las opciones son sinónimos de esa palabra. El orden de los binomials no se invierte (§2.1).

14.1 · Binomials

Binomial	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
spick and **span**	I	limpísimo, como los chorros del oro	The kitchen was spick and span.
cut and **dried**	N	claro y definitivo; decidido de antemano	The issue is not as cut and dried as it seems.
hard and **fast**	N	(una regla) estricta, inamovible; casi siempre there are no hard and fast rules	There are no hard and fast rules about tipping.
(leave sb) high and **dry**	N	dejar en la estacada	When the funding ended, hundreds of students were left high and dry.
home and **dry**	I	con el éxito asegurado (británico)	Two goals up with five minutes left, they thought they were home and dry.
wear and **tear**	N	desgaste por el uso	The policy does not cover normal wear and tear.
by leaps and **bounds**	N	a pasos agigantados	Her English has improved by leaps and bounds.
to all intents and **purposes**	F	a efectos prácticos	To all intents and purposes, the project has been abandoned.
hit and **miss**	N	irregular, a la buena de Dios (hit-and-miss ante sustantivo)	Mobile coverage in the valley is hit and miss.
chop and **change**	I	cambiar continuamente de idea o de plan (británico)	The government keeps chopping and changing its policy.
(fight) tooth and **nail**	N	con uñas y dientes	Residents fought tooth and nail to save the library.
through thick and **thin**	N	en lo bueno y en lo malo	She stood by him through thick and thin.
the ins and **outs** (of)	N	los entresijos	He knows the ins and outs of the planning system.
pick and **choose**	N	poder elegir con libertad	With so many applicants, employers can pick and choose.
kith and **kin**	F	parientes y allegados (literario)	He returned to the island to be among his kith and kin.
alive and **kicking**	I	vivito y coleando	Despite the rumours, the magazine is alive and kicking.
neck and **neck**	N	muy igualados (en una carrera, en una votación)	The two candidates are neck and neck in the polls.
the be-all and **end-all**	N	lo único que importa	Exam results are not the be-all and end-all.

Binomial	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
(by) trial and **error**	N	(por) ensayo y error	We found the right settings by trial and error.
rant and **rave**	I	despotricar	There's no point ranting and raving about it.

14.2 · Comparaciones fijas

Comparación	Reg.	Significado	Ejemplo
like water off a duck's **back**	I	como quien oye llover: las críticas no le afectan	I've told him a hundred times, but it's like water off a duck's back.
like gold **dust**	I	escasísimo y muy buscado (británico)	Tickets for the final are like gold dust.
spread like **wildfire**	N	correr como la pólvora	News of the resignation spread like wildfire.
like a red **rag** to a bull	I	algo que provoca la ira de alguien al instante	Any mention of the referee is like a red rag to a bull.
like a fish out of **water**	N	como pez fuera del agua	At the embassy dinner, I felt like a fish out of water.
like a bull in a china **shop**	I	como un elefante en una cacharrería	He handled the negotiations like a bull in a china shop.
sell like hot **cakes**	I	venderse como churros	The new model is selling like hot cakes.
as plain as **day**	I	más claro que el agua	It was as plain as day that she was lying.
as dead as a **dodo**	I	completamente desaparecido u obsoleto	The idea of a job for life is as dead as a dodo.
as right as **rain**	I	perfectamente bien (de salud)	A good night's sleep and you'll be as right as rain.
like **clockwork**	N	como un reloj, sin un fallo	The whole operation went like clockwork.
avoid sth like the **plague**	N	huir de algo como de la peste	Most politicians avoid the subject like the plague.

> OJO · TRAMPA TÍPICA
>
> High and dry y home and dry solo se diferencian en una palabra y significan lo contrario: quedarse en la estacada frente a tener el éxito asegurado. En la Part 1 pueden aparecer las dos como opciones.

Ya en otra teoría: by and large, few and far between, part and parcel, null and void, first and foremost, tried and tested, odds and ends, rough and ready (UOE-P1 §4.1)

ÍTEM MODELO · PART 1

There are no hard and _____ rules about how long a reference should be, but most run to a single page.

A fast **B** firm **C** strict **D** rigid

Respuesta: A · fast. Hard and fast: estricto, inamovible. Es un binomial; ninguna de sus dos palabras admite sinónimo.

B firm: forma collocation con rules por separado (firm rules), pero no binomial con hard.

C strict: es sinónimo del significado (strict rules existe), no de la forma fija.

D rigid: mismo caso que strict; *hard and rigid no existe.

15 Tabla de repaso por palabra clave

Orden alfabético por la palabra en negrita de las tablas, que es la que suele darse como clave en la Part 4. Para repasar en enero: lee la clave, intenta recordar la expresión y su significado, y solo entonces mira la expresión. Incluye las expresiones remitidas a otras teorías: P1 = UOE-P1_Teoria_v1 y P4 = UOE-P4_Teoria_v1, con su apartado.

	Claves y expresiones
A	**above** a cut above §10 · **account** call sb to account (for) §7; take sth into account P4 5.1; turn sth to (good) account §13 · **air** clear the air §8 · **all** one-size-fits-all §11; warts and all §10 · **allowances** make allowances for P4 5.1 · **apart** poles apart §10 · **arm** chance one's arm §5 · **aspic** preserved in aspic §12
B	**back** get sb's back up §9; like water off a duck's back §14.2 · **backwards** bend over backwards (to) §8 · **balance** hang in the balance §5; strike a balance P1 3.1 · **bargepole** not touch sth with a bargepole §2.5 · **barrel** have sb over a barrel §7 · **basket** put all one's eggs in one basket §5 · **behalf** on sb's behalf / on behalf of sb §8 · **being** for the time being P4 7 · **belt** tighten one's belt §13 · **berth** give sb / sth a wide berth §8 · **bet** a safe bet §5 · **bets** hedge one's bets §5 · **better** think better of sth / -ing §11 · **between** few and far between P1 4.1 · **bill** foot the bill (for) §13 · **blessing** a blessing in disguise P1 4.2 · **bluff** call sb's bluff §11 · **board** back to the drawing board §3 · **books** in sb's good / bad books §8 · **bounds** by leaps and bounds §14.1 · **branch** hold out an olive branch §8 · **bricks** bricks and mortar §13 · **bridge** cross that bridge when we come to it §11 · **buck** pass the buck §7 · **bullet** bite the bullet §11 · **bush** beat about the bush §6 · **button** at the press of a button §12
C	**cakes** sell like hot cakes §14.2 · **call** at sb's beck and call §7 · **candle** not hold a candle to §10 · **cards** hold all the cards §7; on the cards §5 · **carpet** sweep sth under the carpet §2.5 · **cash** strapped for cash §13 · **cat** let the cat out of the bag §6 · **caution** err on the side of caution §5 · **cert** a dead cert §5 · **chance** on the off chance P4 7; stand a chance P4 7 · **change** chop and change §14.1 · **choose** pick and choose §14.1 · **chord** strike a chord P1 3.1 · **clockwork** like clockwork §14.2 · **company** part company (with) §8 · **conclusion** a foregone conclusion P1 3.2 · **conclusions** jump to conclusions §6 · **contention** a bone of contention §8 · **corners** cut corners P1 4.2 · **costs** incur costs P1 3.1 · **course** in due course P4 7; steer a middle course (between) §11 · **cow** a cash cow §13 · **cropper** come a cropper §3 · **cry** a far cry from P1 4.2 · **cue** on cue §12
D	**dark** a shot in the dark §5; in the dark P4 5.2 · **date** past its sell-by date §12 · **day** as plain as day §14.2; call it a day §4; have had its / one's day §12 · **desired** leave a lot to be desired §10 · **disposal** at sb's disposal P4 5.4 · **dodo** as dead as a dodo §14.2 · **doubt** give sb the benefit of the doubt P4 5.1 · **down** be down to sb / sth §5 · **draw** the luck of the draw §5 · **dried** cut and dried §14.1 · **drop** at the drop of a hat P1 4.2 · **dry** (leave sb) high and dry §14.1; home and dry §14.1 · **dust** like gold dust §14.2
E	**ear** play it by ear P4 5.2 · **edge** on edge P4 5.2 · **effort** spare no effort P4 7 · **elephant** a white elephant §13 · **end** at a loose end P4 5.2; at one's wits' end §9 · **end-all** the be-all and end-all §14.1 · **ends** odds and ends P1 4.1 · **error** (by) trial and error §14.1 · **exception** take exception to P4 5.1 · **expense** at the expense of P4 5.4; spare no expense P4 7 · **eye** see eye to eye (with sb on sth) §8; turn a blind eye (to) §6 · **eyelid** not bat an eyelid P1 4.2

	Claves y expresiones
F	**face** put a brave face on sth §9 · **fast** hard and fast §14.1 · **fate** tempt fate §5 · **fence** sit on the fence §11 · **fiddle** play second fiddle (to) §7 · **fire** come under fire P4 5.1 · **flat** fall flat §3; work flat out §4 · **foot** put one's foot down §7; set foot in / on §4 · **foremost** first and foremost P1 4.1 · **front** know sth back to front §6
G	**game** give the game away §6 · **generalisation** a sweeping generalisation P1 3.2 · **glued** glued to one's screen §9 · **go** touch and go P1 4.1 · **good** for good §12 · **gospel** take / treat sth as gospel §6 · **grace** with good / bad grace §9 · **grade** make the grade §3 · **grapevine** hear sth on the grapevine §6 · **grindstone** keep one's nose to the grindstone §4 · **grips** get to grips with §4 · **ground** get sth off the ground §11; stand one's ground §7 · **grudge** harbour a grudge P1 3.1 · **guess** anyone's guess §5 · **guilt** a pang of guilt P1 3.4 · **gun** jump the gun §11
H	**hairs** split hairs §10 · **hand** gain / have the upper hand §7; have a hand in §7; out of hand P4 5.2 · **hands** change hands §13; have time on one's hands §4 · **hard** hard going §3 · **hatchet** bury the hatchet §8 · **head** a head start (on / over) §3 · **headway** make headway (with / in) §3 · **heart** a change of heart §11; lose heart §9; set one's heart on P4 5.2; take sth to heart §9 · **heel** bring sb to heel §7 · **herring** a red herring §10 · **heyday** in its / sb's heyday §12 · **home** nothing to write home about §10 · **hope** a flicker of hope P1 3.4 · **horse** put the cart before the horse §11 · **hour** at the eleventh hour §12
I	**ice** skate on thin ice §5 · **iceberg** the tip of the iceberg §3 · **idea** not have the faintest idea P4 7 · **insignificance** pale into insignificance (beside) §10 · **issue** take issue with P4 5.1
J	**judgement** more by luck than judgement §5 · **jury** the jury is (still) out (on) §6
K	**keep** earn its keep / its place §13 · **kicking** alive and kicking §14.1 · **kin** kith and kin §14.1 · **knowledge** to the best of my knowledge P4 5.4
L	**large** by and large P1 4.1 · **length** keep sb at arm's length §8 · **liberty** take a liberty / liberties (with) §8 · **life** a new lease of life §12 · **light** come to light P4 5.1; see the light of day §3; shed light on P1 3.1 · **likelihood** in all likelihood P4 7 · **line** a fine line (between) §10; draw a line under §11; toe the line P1 4.2; tread a fine line P1 9 · **lip** keep a stiff upper lip §9 · **loggerheads** at loggerheads (with / over) §8 · **look** for the look of the thing §10 · **loss** at a loss for words P4 5.2 · **losses** cut one's losses §13 · **luck** push one's luck §5
M	**mark** wide of the mark §6 · **matter** a different matter altogether §10; a matter of time P4 7 · **means** live beyond one's means §13 · **meet** make ends meet §13 · **mercy** at the mercy of P1 4.3 · **mile** go the extra mile §4 · **mind** cross one's mind P4 5.2; make up one's mind P4 7 · **minds** in two minds P4 7 · **miss** hit and miss §14.1 · **moon** once in a blue moon §12 · **mouthful** a bit of a mouthful §6
N	**nail** (fight) tooth and nail §14.1 · **neck** neck and neck §14.1 · **nerve** touch a raw nerve §9 · **nest** feather one's (own) nest §13 · **nettle** grasp the nettle §11 · **nick** in the nick of time P1 4.2 · **none** second to none P4 3.7 · **nose** pay through the nose (for) §13; put sb's nose out of joint §8 · **nothing** come to nothing §3 · **notice** at short notice P4 7
O	**object** defeat the object / purpose (of) §11 · **occasion** rise to the occasion §4 · **ocean** a drop in the ocean §13 · **odds** against all the odds P4 5.2; beat the odds §5; pay over the odds §13 · **offing** in the offing P1 4.2 · **oil** burn the midnight oil §4 · **one** back to square one §11 · **oneself** be beside oneself (with) §9; keep sth to oneself §6 · **option** have no option but to P4 5.1 · **options** keep one's options open §11 · **order** a tall order §3 · **outs** the ins and outs (of) §14.1 · **own** hold one's own (against) §3
P	**pace** keep pace with P4 5.1 · **pan** a flash in the pan §3 · **paper** on paper … in practice §10 · **par** on a par with P4 5.2; par for the course P1 4.2 · **parcel** part and parcel P1 4.1 · **part** in no small part / measure §10; the best part of §12 · **past** a thing of the past §12 · **peace** make one's peace with §9 · **picnic** no picnic §3 · **pipeline** in the pipeline §12 · **plague** avoid sth like the plague §14.2 · **plate** have a lot on one's plate §4 · **plunge** take the plunge §11 · **point** a case in point §10; beside the point P4 5.2 · **power** wield power P1 3.1 · **praise** damn sb / sth with faint praise §10 · **praises** sing sb's praises §8 · **premium** at a premium §13 · **price** a heavy price P1 3.2 · **profile** keep a low profile §6 · **prove** have nothing to prove §9 · **purposes** to all intents and purposes §14.1
Q	**quarter** from an unlikely quarter §8

	Claves y expresiones
R	**rag** like a red rag to a bull §14.2 · **rain** as right as rain §14.2 · **ravages** the ravages of time §12 · **rave** rant and rave §14.1 · **ready** rough and ready P1 4.1 · **reckoned** a force to be reckoned with §7 · **recognition** beyond (all) recognition §12 · **red** in the red / in the black §13 · **regard** hold sb in high regard P4 5.2 · **rein** give sb free rein (to) §7; keep sb / sth on a tight rein §7 · **roost** rule the roost §7 · **ropes** learn the ropes P1 4.2 · **run** in the long run P4 7
S	**safe** play it safe §5 · **sailing** plain sailing §3 · **sake** for its own sake §10; for sb's sake P4 5.4 · **salt** take sth with a pinch of salt P1 4.2; worth one's salt §13 · **say** have a say in P4 5.1; have the final say / the last word §7 · **scratch** from scratch §4 · **sea** all at sea §6 · **secret** an open secret §6 · **service** pay lip service to §8 · **shoestring** on a shoestring §13 · **shop** like a bull in a china shop §14.2 · **short** fall short of P4 7 · **shot** a long shot §5 · **shots** call the shots §7 · **shoulder** a chip on one's shoulder (about) §9; give sb the cold shoulder §8; look over one's shoulder §9 · **skeleton** a skeleton in the cupboard §2.5 · **skin** by the skin of one's teeth P1 4.2 · **sleep** lose sleep over §9 · **span** spick and span §14.1 · **spare** with time to spare §4 · **spell** break the spell §9 · **spirits** in high spirits §9 · **spur** on the spur of the moment P1 4.2 · **stacked** the odds are stacked against §5 · **stage** take sth a stage / step further §4 · **stake** at stake P4 5.2 · **standstill** grind to a standstill / halt §3 · **stick** get the wrong end of the stick §6 · **stone** leave no stone unturned §4; set in stone §12 · **storm** a storm in a teacup §2.5 · **strength** go from strength to strength §3 · **stretch** at full stretch §4; by no stretch of the imagination P4 5.2 · **stride** take sth in one's stride §4 · **strings** hold the purse strings §13; pull strings §7 · **stripe** of every stripe §10 · **stroke** at a stroke §12 · **struggle** an uphill struggle / battle §3 · **sway** hold sway (over) §7 · **swing** in full swing §4 · **swoop** in one fell swoop §12 · **sword** a double-edged sword §10
T	**tables** turn the tables (on) §7 · **take** give and take P1 4.1 · **task** take sb to task (for) §8 · **tear** wear and tear §14.1 · **teeth** cut one's teeth (on) §4; grind one's teeth §9 · **tenterhooks** on tenterhooks §9 · **terms** on good terms with P4 7; on its own terms §10 · **tested** tried and tested P1 4.1 · **tether** at the end of one's tether §9 · **that** leave it at that §11 · **there** neither here nor there §10 · **thin** spread oneself too thin §4; through thick and thin §14.1 · **thought** spare a thought for §8 · **thoughts** have second thoughts (about) §11 · **thumb** a rule of thumb §10 · **tide** turn the tide §12 · **time** ahead of one's / its time §12; stand the test of time §12 · **together** put two and two together §6 · **toll** take its toll on P4 5.1 · **touch** lose touch with P4 7 · **trace** sink without trace §3 · **trumpet** blow one's own trumpet §2.5
V	**value** take sth at face value §6 · **view** with a view to P4 5.4 · **void** null and void P1 4.1
W	**wake** in the wake of P1 4.3 · **wall** drive sb up the wall §9; go to the wall §3; hit a brick wall §3 · **wane** on the wane §12 · **was** not what it was §12 · **water** hold water §10; like a fish out of water §14.2 · **way** give way to P4 5.1; go out of one's way P4 5.2; rub sb up the wrong way §9 · **wayside** fall by the wayside §3 · **weight** carry weight (with) §7; pull one's weight §4; throw one's weight about §7 · **while** worth sb's while P4 7 · **whim** on a whim §11 · **wildfire** spread like wildfire §14.2 · **wind** get wind of §6; sail close to the wind §5 · **wing** take sb under one's wing §8 · **wiser** be none the wiser §6 · **wood** touch wood §2.5 · **word** not believe a word of it §6; take my word for it P4 5.2 · **words** not mince one's words §10 · **work** have one's work cut out §4 · **worse** think none / not any the worse of sb §8 · **worst** assume / fear the worst §11 · **worth** get one's money's worth §13 · **wraps** under wraps §6